suffered, found it almost impossible to get recognized as refugees. During the bloody decade of the 1980s in Central America, fewer than 5 percent of Salvadorans and Guatemalans fleeing death squads, bombs, and scorched-earth tactics were granted refugee status.

Only Cubans received a warm welcome from the U.S. government that included virtually automatic refugee status, along with special federal programs for jobs, education, and housing. Even Puerto Ricans, who are U.S. citizens, did not receive the special benefits designed for Cubans. Most other Latin Americans encountered harsh immigration restrictions and little access to social programs or benefits.

Most of the Cubans considered themselves, as they were considered by the U.S. government, to be political refugees, fleeing from Communism. Mexicans and Puerto Ricans, in contrast, were considered to be economic migrants – people who came to the United States in search of economic opportunity, rather than for political reasons.

Yet the difference between "political" and "economic" migrants is not as clear-cut as it might appear at first glance. In both capitalist and Communist countries, governments pursued economic policies that had effects on the population and in particular, on the distribution of the country's resources. In Mexico, it was the rural poor who found their economic options choked, and who came to the United States to work, often under miserable conditions, to support their families back home. In Cuba, it was primarily urban professionals who found their economic options cut off by the Revolution. However, as I have argued elsewhere, "U.S. policy was based on the premise that in Communist countries, economic difficulties were the result of government policies, and were therefore political." In the case of a capitalist country like Mexico, however, "U.S. policy was based on the idea that poverty was merely an economic, not a political, problem."[7]

Another unique aspect of the Cuban migration was the arrival of some 14,000 unaccompanied children through a program developed by the U.S. government and the Catholic Church called Operation Peter Pan. "Many parents in Cuba," explains historian María Cristina García, "sent their children ahead to the United States, hoping to be reunited at a later date. Some parents worried about political indoctrination in Cuban